attempts to outsource the task to members of the Mafia. These are discussed in chapter two.

What's in a name?

What name is given to the events of 1962 is also important. Cubans refer to the 'October crisis'. Philip Brenner explains that from a Cuban perspective the crisis began in November 1961 and did not end until November 1962, thirteen months later.[34] The Soviets (and Russians) referred to the 'Caribbean crisis', while the noted French scholar Benoît Pelopidas refers simply to 'the crisis'.[35] For ease of reference, 'Cuban missile crisis' is mainly used here, while acknowledging that perhaps the most apposite term was coined by the British Prime Minister, Harold Macmillan, when, on 22 October 1962, he wrote in his diary, 'The first day of the World Crisis!'[36]

Martin Sherwin places the events of October 1962 within the broader framework of the nuclear age and writes of the 'long Cuban missile crisis of 1945–1962'.[37] The events of 1945 do indeed provide a valuable framework. They illustrate key themes and issues in this book. These include misperceptions and misunderstandings (especially those of political leaders) the command and control of nuclear weapons, and the disconnect between political leaders and subordinates, especially those in the military. It is the interaction (and potential interaction) between these, and other factors, that generate the clearest paths to Armageddon (and beyond). What they also do is to illuminate an essential factor in explaining the course of the crisis and its outcome: luck. The bombing of Nagasaki is one of the best illustrations of the importance of luck in the nuclear age, when luck is regarded as where events are beyond human control.[38] And as Martin Sherwin argues, the Cuban missile crisis remains 'history's luckiest non-event'.[39]

The vice of origin

The atomic bombing of Japan has long been the focus for often heated debate, including how far President Harry Truman's primary aim was to end